

The Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil

Open to Ezekiel 28.

One of the great teaching tools God uses is the nature He gave us. When I was born again, I entered the kingdom of God. I was translated out of darkness into the kingdom of light and His Son. I came in with a new nature that had the capacity to understand spiritual things.

I did not know everything, and neither did you, but we came in with that capacity.

My new nature is not statistical; it is moral. It knows what is right and wrong. It is not supernatural in the sense that if I drove into a city and needed an address, my new nature could manufacture it. That is outside information. But it is moral.

When I received the baptism of the Holy Spirit, that happened to me. The Holy Spirit is one Person. For all eternity, I am another. I am an individual being. I am my own entity. I will be an individual forever, and so will you. God is another Person. The Holy Spirit has stepped in.

He is the earnest of your inheritance. You know what earnest money is. You put earnest money down on a house as sincerity toward the final possession of that house. The Holy Spirit is the earnest of heaven, meaning I am the final purchased possession. The Holy Spirit is what heaven has given me to see through the final obtaining of the possession.

He is the power for sanctification: spirit, soul, and body. He is the keeping power. He is the statistical part. He is all-knowing, and He has offered Himself as an earnest to see to it that I make it home as heaven's final possession.

It seems like God's love and that nature are being taught when He provides a supernatural language. You can even go about your business and do other things while you are praying, because a good portion of it He leaves you out of.

I used to think edification meant feelings. Edification does not necessarily mean feelings. When we say feelings, we are usually talking about good ones. Sometimes the feelings you get from edification are not exactly good ones, because He is trying to get you to turn loose of something so He can build you up above it.

Of course, none of you has ever been there. You have never held on to anything you should not have.

I do not know anyone who loves you as much as God does. Once in a while you see people come close in humanity, in agape. They build accounts, lay fortunes aside, or leave money behind when they die to make sure somebody they love is taken care of, reaching beyond the grave. You see things like that from time to time. People give their lives for other people's freedom, even though they will never live out that freedom themselves.

Nevertheless, what kind of love did God have that He supplied this language so He could pray prayers through you that He could answer? That is edification.

Feelings of joy and the presence of God are results of edification. If I lean toward wanting the presence of God more than anything else, I will lean toward private worship. But edification is a revelation gift. It is a process of building you up in God.

I cannot think of someone who would go this far: supply the language, supply the prayer, supply the mind in the prayer, supply the other two members of the Godhead to answer the prayer, and then borrow your authority to pray the prayer with, so you can be the benefactor of all of it. And still we work on failure.

This nature I have, and you have, came when we were born again. I came into the kingdom as a must-be-born-again child. Jesus said to become as a child, a stripling youngster.

I have a nature that can know about God, and I have another side of my nature that can contain the fruit: love, brotherly kindness, peace. My spiritual mind is a prototype of Christ. I do not have His personal mind, but I do have the mind of Christ as standard equipment for the new creation. I can understand spiritual things, and so can you.

I also have a capacity to pool and reservoir the love of God. I can hardly get off this source of information because it is explaining more about God than I have ever known.

The more He pours into my spirit and builds me up, the more of His love I receive. The more I receive His love, the more I can understand the things about His nature that cause Him to move in certain directions because of love. Before I had the capacity to understand it, I did not understand why He did certain things.

That part of my nature that can love has been enhanced by receiving the love of God, so I can understand certain things He operates in because He is love.

I am starting to understand that when God came from eternity somewhere for our creation, He built a universe we cannot see the end of. We look through powerful telescopes and send them into outer space so their view is not hindered by atmosphere. We keep looking, trying to see the end of something, and we cannot.

Every one of those stars, suns, reflectors, and planets is bigger or smaller, somewhere around the size of our planet. There is one giant out there, and I read an article that said if our sun were placed in its center, our earth could orbit inside the circumference of that star. It just hangs out there somewhere, and we are worrying about our gas bill.

When God wanted to make a point with Abraham, He said, "Can you number these stars?" You can believe My promise.

You have a nature like His. You have the third Person of the Godhead. You are family. Who would He trust you with but a trusted member of the Godhead Himself? Your teaching and guidance were entrusted to family.

When He offers a reward, it is not Cracker Jack. He has given you everything you need to come into it. There would be no point in rewards for services rendered if there were nothing to overcome. Do not think reward is measured only in numbers. It is measured by the worth of a soul and your obedience.

I am called to preach, teach, and some other things we are figuring out. I spend my days preparing myself and praying. I take it seriously. He has gotten me past most snares and traps. When you will not let yourself have any access out of something except God, it is quite a ride. But I understand what is happening to the foundation, and the foundation will give us revival.

My first calling is soul winning. The second is my vocation, what He has called me to in the kingdom. The third is my occupation, what usually puts food on the table. Sometimes your vocation and occupation are the same. Mine are.

I do not care about making money because, as far as I can see, I am not called to that system. It does not interest me. This is what I am called to do.

But it dawned on me that if I were an entrepreneur, what would make me think my ministry to people was any less important? I get everybody together in a building and hope to get you to conquer the whole world. That is my great hope. But the entrepreneur is called to people too.

Anyone who goes out in public, whatever God asks you to do in vocation and occupation, will deal with people. Those people around you are as important to God in your relationship to them, your call, and your ministry, as mine are in here. Just because I am called to collect you together and talk to you does not mean your call to people out there is any less than mine in here.

Whatever I am called to, and wherever I am called, it always boils down to one thing: people, people, people.

Heaven and earth will pass. Hebrews says like an old garment, He will take the outer layer off. The elements will pass away with fervent heat. When they are subjected to something like hell, the elements will not even survive. Somehow we are going to get a new heaven and a new earth. I think it will go back like the garden to some degree, but more adapted to a new creation. We will have glorified bodies.

People think, "I am really going to miss certain things." In heaven, you will not have the capacity to miss anything except deep-seated relationships: relationship with other people as beings, the love of God, and creation in God.

What makes this world go around? Hollywood follows what makes the world go around. They are always on the forefront giving people what they want. That is why there is more lust, more violence, more of this and that, because that is the heartsick core of the death nature with no restraint.

Lust is a perversion of something pure, which is love. There are things you think you are really going to miss, but in the perfected state, when we have glorified bodies and are part of a new creation, it will not even be the same regarding marriage.

The Sadducees were sad, you see, because they did not believe in the resurrection. They asked Jesus about a woman who had seven husbands and which one would be hers in the resurrection. Jesus gave a nugget:

In the resurrection they neither marry, nor are given in marriage, but are as the angels of God in heaven.

In that aspect, they are like the angels.

We are the family of God. That is why Jesus said, "Call no man on this earth father." He was not being disrespectful. There would be no being born again if I had not been born the first time. What is born of flesh is flesh, and what is born of Spirit is spirit. If you did not come into existence through the first birth, which is flesh, there would be no second birth.

I will always honor my father and mother. That is a commandment, even though I never knew one of them except for the beatings I remember, before Mom ran him off with his bayonet. She tried to get him, or the bayonet would not have gone through the wall. For some reason, he left.

I will always honor my mother too, who died of cirrhosis of the liver as an alcoholic. I have to believe she was saved because I did not know how to pray much then. I was in my late twenties when she died.

In Oregon thirty years ago, falling down was a big deal. Where people fell down under the power, you wanted to go. We would drive over the pass, stay in a little trailer, go back and put in ten hours a day for six days, then go do it again. I had to get somewhere God was moving.

One of the first times I heard the Lord, and I really know it was Him, He went way overboard to emphasize Himself because of how I was believing for my mother. He said, "Get up and go home."

For Him to tell me to do that was something. I was starving for God. But I said, "We have to go." We went home and got in at two in the morning. My mother was knocking on the door at five in the morning, and she lived in California. It was the first time I ever saw her cry and tell me she loved me.

She came to a little prayer meeting I was trying to do and cried. I never saw her again. I have to believe she made it. Why did she come? Why did she listen? Why did she cry? She was on the wagon, then had a relapse into drinking, and it killed her. But I have to believe.

I will always honor my father and mother and honor God. I would not be here without them. If all I can honor my father for is being here, then that is what I will honor him for.

The first birth was of the flesh. The second is of the Spirit. God is my Father. When we get there, we are going to be one big family. That is why Jesus said there is no marrying or giving in marriage. You will not run around heaven looking for a wife. You will have nothing in you that cares about that whole aspect.

You are going to look good, because Jesus was cut off at thirty-three and a half from the land of the living. You will get no older. Your spirit is getting no older, and it will be clothed with a glorified body that really looks good.

We will have a new heaven, a new earth, and a new creation. Your life there will be fuller than here. The things you think make life worth living now are mostly portrayed by Hollywood because God created them in an unperverted state. What brings people great pleasure is living in one another, success, and the good life. He created what brings joy before it was perverted.

So what makes you think a creation higher than that will not bring tremendous joy? It will revolve around us being part of what He is doing. All He has to do is look at you like you are going to get a reward, and you would have conquered a thousand worlds like ours just for that look.

Do not think you are giving up anything. You are not.

Jesus came from forever for our universe, for my home. He built this for me. It is my home. It is going to be remodeled. After six thousand years of sin and one millennium, it can use a little repair. That is what it will get. It will be adapted to our creation.

When Peter said, "We have left all to follow You. What do we get?" Jesus said no man has left houses, lands, father, mother, family, children, or wife who will not receive eternal life and a hundredfold in this life. The hundredfold was not money. He said mothers, fathers, sisters, and brothers. The only one He left out of that equation was wives. A lot of people are trying to do that now.

Can you imagine the place God lived? As His sons and daughters whom He loves, can you imagine how the earth must have been as a Garden of Eden? Why would He not build us a house like His?

That is what our house was like. He put your great forefather there. You came through Adam's strand of DNA. God created humanity; He created a strand. He took Adam's bone marrow and altered one chromosome, and there was the woman. He took her from him. He did not get her from the ground and breathe into her the breath of life. He had already created man in one single strand of DNA.

You came through that. You should have seen Adam's real estate before the devil got it.

I can just imagine what Eden was like before the fall. Tremendous place.

I have talked about God's love because understanding God through that nature is opening more and more about who He is in areas I did not understand. Sometimes I am so anxious that when I start understanding Him, I almost run ahead of Him. My faith is running through the ceiling.

To me, establishing the foundation is not a slow process anymore. I am glad to do it. I get to run ahead and look at the building He wants to put on it. That gives me patience. The attributes He wants me to have are what I end up wanting to have.

Can you imagine what our house was like? God's Eden, where He lived, had Lucifer there as the anointed cherub that covereth. I knew he had something to do with worship. When I first heard these statements, as far as I was concerned, he probably covered everything and opened creation up to worship and approach God.

But when Scripture put him in the Eden of God as the anointed cherub that covereth, the question became: cover what?

I can understand more of what he did there by understanding what Adam did here. God called our house Eden again. It is like His. He put Adam in it to dress it. What do you think Adam was doing, if not covering? He put him there to dress it.

Something happened further back than you could probably measure time, before our beginning, before there was a Milky Way, before there was an Eden we could call our house. Maybe we are in a galaxy and maybe He had others and made this our home. I do not know that. I know natural creation is made of the same substances, and if you find new substances, the basic unit is still matter as we know it, not spiritual base.

We will have a new heaven and a new earth. I do not know if He is going to change the whole universe and the Milky Way to be compatible with the new creation, or just the heavens surrounding our planet with a new heaven and a new earth. It really does not matter.

This I do know: Jesus said Lucifer was a liar from the beginning and the father of it. When he entered our creation in the Garden of Eden, he was already fallen.

In the beginning of his creation, he was perfect. So the fall had to take place before our beginning and after his creation, when he was perfect. By the beginning of ours, he was already full of iniquity, the father of lies, and the father of it. When Jesus said "the father of it," He meant Satan provided the life for the whole process, the whole hurricane, the whole tornado from which all iniquity and lies come.

And think about this: you little shoe-salesman believer have more power and authority than he does.

Someone says, "But I am the least of the least."

You still have more than he does.

Behold, I give you power over all the power of the enemy.

Hallelujah.

For I am love, and My foundation that is sure is based on My love. He who has this has no fear or torment, and your foundation is sure. So fear not and rejoice. Have I not provided for you all things?

Be steadfast and unmoving in My Word. Be steadfast and unmoving in the development of My love, and you will see. You will prevail. Not only will you prevail, you will conquer.

For I have much darkness to be visited and a shortage of those to do it with. So be strong and know that I am He who is the power. I am He who works the signs and wonders. I am He who will move heaven and earth and push darkness back for the salvation of one soul.

So be strong and know that it is I who works My life in you.

Hallelujah, Jesus.

God would tell the devil, "I know where you are," by prophesying to a king whose throne Satan had taken up. In Ezekiel 28:9, He says:

Wilt thou yet say before him that slayeth thee, I am God?

He prophesied to the king of Tyre, but look who He was really talking to. He might have said, "I shall say unto thee, Hitler," and in the next sentence be saying, "So, Satan, you are not going to..." That is how He would do it.

Verse 12 says:

Son of man, take up a lamentation upon the king of Tyrus, and say unto him, Thus saith the Lord GOD; Thou sealest up the sum, full of wisdom, and perfect in beauty.

Then verse 13:

Thou hast been in Eden the garden of God.

Every precious stone was his covering: sardius, topaz, diamond, beryl, onyx, jasper, sapphire, emerald, carbuncle, and gold. The workmanship of his tabrets and pipes was prepared in him the day he was created.

Verse 14:

Thou art the anointed cherub that covereth; and I have set thee so.

He was upon the holy mountain of God and walked up and down in the midst of the stones of fire.

Verse 15:

Thou wast perfect in thy ways from the day that thou wast created, till iniquity was found in thee.

Let me show you something. Let us talk about the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil for a minute.

Go to Ezekiel 31:2. God is addressing Pharaoh, king of Egypt, and the multitude like his greatness. Then jump down to verse 9:

I have made him fair by the multitude of his branches, so that all the trees of Eden, that were in the garden of God, envied him.

Verse 10 says:

Therefore thus saith the Lord GOD; Because thou hast lifted up thyself in height, and he hath shot up his top among the thick boughs, and his heart is lifted up in his height...

Is that not interesting? "All the trees of Eden that were in the garden of God envied him."

Envy a tree? What was Lucifer? A tree? Did he plant one? What did they partake of? Were they warned against something that had its own life?

Go to Genesis 2:7. Somebody says, "Did God put the Tree of the Knowledge of Good and Evil in the garden? Did He want a temptation station so He could prove creation?"

That is what theology says: God planted that tree there because creation had to be proved. That is one theory.

Who put it there? Did God plant it there? What did He want? Did He want to prove us? How about the Tree of Life? What was it?

It is interesting that Ezekiel talks about a tree that towered above the others in height and beauty, and the others envied him.

Do snakes talk? Genesis says the serpent was more subtle than the other beasts of the field, deceptively wise. Did the serpent, when he had arms, lean on the old picket gate and have chocolate milk with Betsy the cow while they discussed theological discourses of astronomical proportions?

If "the other beasts of the field" means they all talked, then what was the tree?

I remember one well-known teacher. I got the biggest kick out of him. He was teaching what caused Eve to take the apple. He said, "Was it the apple? Down to the core of things..." The only alternative fruit I can think of is that it was not the apple on the tree, but the pear on the ground.

This teacher said Eve was so taken back that she went into shock. She was in the garden, and suddenly this talking snake came up to her. She was so shocked that a snake would be talking that she just reached out and took the fruit. I almost ran off the road. I was waiting for him to finish the joke. It was not a joke.

So who was this serpent? Did he have arms? When he was cursed to eat the dust of the earth, did that mean before then he had beautiful arms and afterward he could not walk around anymore and had to crawl like us?

If all of that is symbolism, what was the tree?

That was not the first reduction Lucifer received from God when he moved into our creation. He got reduced in authority again. One archangel could kill 180,000 Assyrians overnight to turn captivity in Israel's direction. Just one. Imagine what Lucifer could do at full power.

But what are you? Dust you are, and to dust you shall return. What did God create your flesh out of? What are we still wearing that is going to give way to a glorified body?

Paul said flesh and blood cannot inherit the kingdom. If it cannot inherit it, how can it be made perfect in it?

Satan was reduced to eat the dust of the earth. That is, he was reduced to operate on the flesh level. He cannot even conquer a Hitler kingdom without getting a man to do it through.

He could hardly get spiritually dead men, as long as they could get a case of beer, drive their four-wheel drive, jump over other cars, and relieve the pressure, to leave their wives and stop taking care of them. The only way he could get anything done was through flesh.

But he is pretty good at that.

It is the same with God in this sense: for you to remain who you are and Him to remain who He is, He cannot force Himself on you. You have to decide. After you decide, you even get to decide how much of Him you want.

The devil is trying to play you like a pawn.

What a surge. The devil is defeated, is he not?

By a shoe salesman.